Somehow I thought that the story would elicit a mass of mail denouncing my own portrayal of McCarthyism, or supporting it, but I got nothing either one way or the other. It may be that my satire of McCarthy was so subtle that everyone missed it.

26

On September 23, 1952, I listened to Richard M. Nixon give his "Checkers" speech, the one in which he denied (for the first time, but not the last) that he was a crook. I had disliked him intensely for his

6 See The Martian Way and Other Stories.

campaign tactics against Helen Gahagan Douglas, and for his active role in the McCarthy-like tactics of the House Un-American Activities Committee. In the Alger Hiss affair, I was convinced that Hiss was innocent and that Whittaker Chambers was a liar who was conniving with Nixon.

Now as I listened to Nixon give his patently dishonest speech, I felt a hatred for him growing that was never thereafter to diminish. I felt him to be an utter hypocrite with an instinct for personal aggrandizement at all costs. I went around saying, bitterly, "If the Soviet Union should conquer the United States tomorrow and should need a Quisling to rule us in their interest, Nixon would be their man."

I still believe that.

What made it worse, of course, was that I was quite convinced that the American public would fall for the speech—and it did.

2 7

More and more I was trying to establish myself as an independent entity at the Medical School. I managed to get a small grant from the Atomic Energy Commission with myself as principal investigator. That meant that I myself had money to spend.

I could hire Howard Bensusan to work for me now. Bensusan was a victim of polio and had to maneuver about on crutches, but he was cheerful, driving, and bright.

I also began to give a small course of my own for graduate students —one on protein structure.